

The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County

Mark Twain · 1865

First published: New York Saturday Press, Nov 1865

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Celebrated_Jumping_Frog_of_Calaveras_County,_and_Other_Sketches/The_Celebrated_Jumping_Frog_of_Calaveras_County (revision 14826073), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 7–11 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County suggest about tall tales and frontier humor?
- What does The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County suggest about storytelling?
- What does The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County suggest about trickery?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*tall tales and frontier humor* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County

Focus: the art of the deadpan tall tale

Content note (animal cruelty played for comedy (frog loaded with shot)): Sensitive content: Animal cruelty played for comedy (frog loaded with shot). Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes animal cruelty played for comedy (frog loaded with shot).
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

The genteel narrator asks old Simon Wheeler about a Reverend Leonidas W. Smiley and instead hears, in dead earnest, the story of Jim Smiley, who would bet on anything. Smiley trains a frog, Dan'l Webster, to jump. A stranger fills the frog with quail shot while Smiley fetches a second frog, and wins the bet. When Wheeler starts on a one-eyed cow, the narrator escapes.

Background: Published in the New York Saturday Press in 1865; it made Twain nationally famous.

Significance: A landmark of American vernacular humor and the frame narrative; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: What makes someone a good storyteller? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes animal cruelty played for comedy (frog loaded with shot).

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are straddle, garrulous, uncover, sociable, cherished. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "And when it come to fair and square jumping on a dead level, he could get over more ground at one straddle than any animal of his breed you ever see." In this sentence it means: to sit or stand with one leg on each side. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County would have known. Published in the New York Saturday Press in 1865; it made Twain nationally famous. Why does this story matter? A landmark of American vernacular humor and the frame narrative; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for diction / vocabulary.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "In compliance with the request of a friend of mine, who wrote me from the East, I called on good-natured, garrulous old Simon Wheeler, and inquired after my friend's friend, Leonidas W." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to the art of the deadpan tall tale? I circle "garrulous", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find diction / vocabulary, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for diction / vocabulary.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of diction / vocabulary. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *In compliance with the request of a friend of mine, who wrote me from the East, I called on good-natured, garrulous old Simon Wheeler, and inquired after my friend's friend, Leonidas W. Smiley, as requested to do, and I hereunto append the result. I have a lurking suspicion that Leonidas W. Smiley is a myth; that my friend never knew such a personage; and that he only conjectured that, if I asked old Wheeler about him, it would remind him of his infamous Jim Smiley, and he would go to work and bore me nearly to death with some infernal reminiscence of him as long and tedious as it should be useless to me. If that was the design, it certainly succeeded.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Diction / vocabulary, Point of view, Structure: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County develops the idea of the art of the deadpan tall tale. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to tall tales and frontier humor? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about the art of the deadpan tall tale, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how diction / vocabulary shapes the art of the deadpan tall tale. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
straddle (verb)	to sit or stand with one leg on each side	*And when it come to fair and square jumping on a dead level, he could get over more ground at one straddle than any animal of his breed you ever see.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
garrulous (adjective)	talking too much, especially about unimportant things	*In compliance with the request of a friend of mine, who wrote me from the East, I called on good-natured, garrulous old Simon Wheeler, and inquired after my friend's friend, Leonidas W.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
uncover (verb)	to remove a covering from; to reveal	*But as soon as money was up on him, he was a different dog; his underjaw'd begin to stick out like the fo'castle of a steamboat, and his teeth would uncover, and shine savage like the furnaces.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
sociable (adjective)	friendly and fond of company	*At the door I met the sociable Wheeler returning, and he button- holed me and recommenced:*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cherished (verb)	be fond of; be attached to	*I told him a friend of mine had commissioned me to make some inquiries about a cherished companion of his boyhood named Leonidas W.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
enterprising (adjective)	full of energy and willing to try new things	*But, by your leave, I did not think that a continuation of the history of the enterprising vagabond Jim Smiley would be likely to afford me much information concerning the Rev.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
commissioned (verb)	gave someone a task to carry out	*I told him a friend of mine had commissioned me to make some inquiries about a cherished companion of his boyhood named Leonidas W.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
continuation (noun)	the act of going on with something	*But, by your leave, I did not think that a continuation of the history of the enterprising vagabond Jim Smiley would*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

		be likely to afford me much information concerning the Rev.	

Discussion questions

1. What makes someone a good storyteller?
2. Where does diction / vocabulary appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with tall tales and frontier humor?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Whom does the narrator ask Simon Wheeler about? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Leonidas W. Smiley
2. What was Jim Smiley known for? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Betting on anything
3. What is the frog's name? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Dan'l Webster
4. How does the stranger win the bet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He fills Smiley's frog with quail shot
5. How does Wheeler tell the story? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In a serious, monotonous, deadpan way
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The genteel narrator asks old Simon Wheeler about a Reverend Leonidas W. Smiley and instead hears, in dead earnest, the story of Jim Smiley, who would bet on anything. Smiley trains a frog, Dan'l Webster, to jump. A stranger fills the frog with quail shot while Smiley fetches a second frog, and wins the bet. When Wheeler starts on a one-eyed cow, the narrator escapes.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “And when it come to fair and square jumping on a dead level, he could get over more ground at one straddle than any animal of his breed you ever see.” What does “straddle” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: straddle: to sit or stand with one leg on each side.

10. Reread: “In compliance with the request of a friend of mine, who wrote me from the East, I called on good-natured, garrulous old Simon Wheeler, and inquired after my friend's friend, Leonidas W.” What does “garrulous” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: garrulous: talking too much, especially about unimportant things.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County” suggest about the art of the deadpan tall tale? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A landmark of American vernacular humor and the frame narrative; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1.
2. Find one example of diction / vocabulary in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
3. How does the point of view in this story shape what we understand about the art of the deadpan tall tale? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
4. In the passage that begins “In compliance with the request of a friend of mine, who wrote me from the East, I called on good-natured, garrulous old Simon Wheeler, and inquired after my friend's friend,…”, why might Twain have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: The genteel narrator asks old Simon Wheeler about a Reverend Leonidas W. Smiley and instead hears, in dead earnest, the story of Jim Smiley, who would bet on anything. Smiley trains a frog, Dan'l Webster, to jump. A stranger fills the frog with quail shot while Smiley fetches a second frog, and…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County” set up that the rest of The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What makes someone a good storyteller?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with tall tales and frontier humor? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
10. Background: Published in the New York Saturday Press in 1865; it made Twain nationally famous. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A landmark of American vernacular humor and the frame narrative; in Gale's Short Stories for Students vol. 1." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the art of the deadpan tall tale? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to storytelling: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Twain need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the diction / vocabulary in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County" treats the art of the deadpan tall tale with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve tall tales and frontier humor? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the art of the deadpan tall tale? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Mark Twain about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Diction / vocabulary:** look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Point of view**: who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know
- Also notice **Structure**: how the story is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz

1. Whom does the narrator ask Simon Wheeler about?
   A. Andrew Jackson
   B. Dan'l Webster
   C. Jim Smiley
   D. Leonidas W. Smiley
2. What was Jim Smiley known for?
   A. Fighting
   B. Preaching
   C. Betting on anything
   D. Gold mining
3. What is the frog's name?
   A. Andrew Jackson
   B. Jumper
   C. Old Hickory
   D. Dan'l Webster
4. How does the stranger win the bet?
   A. He trains a faster frog
   B. He bribes the judge
   C. He scares the frog
   D. He fills Smiley's frog with quail shot
5. How does Wheeler tell the story?
   A. In a whisper
   B. With wild laughter
   C. In a serious, monotonous, deadpan way
   D. As a poem
6. In the line “And when it come to fair and square jumping on a dead level, he could get over more ground at one straddle than any animal of his breed you ever see.”, what does “straddle” most nearly mean?
   A. friendly and fond of company
   B. talking too much, especially about unimportant things
   C. to sit or stand with one leg on each side
   D. to remove a covering from; to reveal
7. In the line “In compliance with the request of a friend of mine, who wrote me from the East, I called on good-natured, garrulous old Simon Wheeler, and inquired after my friend's friend, Leonidas W.”, what does “garrulous” most nearly mean?
   A. to sit or stand with one leg on each side
   B. to remove a covering from; to reveal
   C. talking too much, especially about unimportant things
   D. friendly and fond of company

Answer key: 1. D (Leonidas W. Smiley); 2. C (Betting on anything); 3. D (Dan'l Webster); 4. D (He fills Smiley's frog with quail shot); 5. C (In a serious, monotonous, deadpan way); 6. C (to sit or stand with one leg on each side); 7. C (talking too much, especially about unimportant things)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.12, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County,” how does Twain show the art of the deadpan tall tale? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the diction / vocabulary you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): In The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County, how does Twain develop the idea of the art of the deadpan tall tale? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the diction / vocabulary in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County develops the idea of the art of the deadpan tall tale. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and point of view shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County (where it begins, turns and ends) and its diction / vocabulary shape the reader's understanding of the art of the deadpan tall tale. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County suggests about the art of the deadpan tall tale. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's diction / vocabulary and point of view), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Mark Twain uses diction / vocabulary in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County to complicate the reader's understanding of the art of the deadpan tall tale. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the art of the deadpan tall tale responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the art of the deadpan tall tale follows or bends those conventions, using the diction / vocabulary as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County and its treatment of the art of the deadpan tall tale. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's diction / vocabulary and point of view, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County as evidence for a larger claim about the art of the deadpan tall tale in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the art of the deadpan tall tale. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County.

SAT-style questions

1. *But as soon as money was up on him, he was a different dog; his underjaw'd begin to stick out like the fo'castle of a steamboat, and his teeth would uncover, and shine savage like the furnaces.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “uncover” most nearly mean?

   A. full of energy and willing to try new things

   B. the act of going on with something

   C. to remove a covering from; to reveal

   D. gave someone a task to carry out

2. *In compliance with the request of a friend of mine, who wrote me from the East, I called on good-natured, garrulous old Simon Wheeler, and inquired after my friend's friend, Leonidas W. Smiley, as requested to do, and I hereunto append the result. I have a lurking suspicion that Leonidas W. Smiley is a myth; that my friend never knew such a personage; and that he only conjectured that, if I asked old Wheeler about him, it would remind him of his infamous Jim Smiley, and he would go to work and bore me nearly to death with some infernal reminiscence of him as long and tedious as it should be useless to me. If that was the design, it certainly succeeded.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County”?

   A. Wishes that defy fate

   B. The art of the deadpan tall tale

   C. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

D. Waking into a changed nation

SAT key: 1. C (to remove a covering from; to reveal); 2. B (The art of the deadpan tall tale)

Whole-book test

The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Whom does the narrator ask Simon Wheeler about?
   A. Andrew Jackson
   B. Dan'l Webster
   C. Jim Smiley
   D. Leonidas W. Smiley
2. What was Jim Smiley known for?
   A. Fighting
   B. Preaching
   C. Betting on anything
   D. Gold mining
3. What is the frog's name?
   A. Andrew Jackson
   B. Jumper
   C. Old Hickory
   D. Dan'l Webster
4. How does the stranger win the bet?
   A. He trains a faster frog
   B. He bribes the judge
   C. He scares the frog
   D. He fills Smiley's frog with quail shot
5. How does Wheeler tell the story?
   A. In a whisper
   B. With wild laughter
   C. In a serious, monotonous, deadpan way
   D. As a poem
6. In the line “And when it come to fair and square jumping on a dead level, he could get over more ground at one straddle than any animal of his breed you ever see.”, what does “straddle” most nearly mean?
   A. friendly and fond of company
   B. talking too much, especially about unimportant things
   C. to sit or stand with one leg on each side
   D. to remove a covering from; to reveal

7. In the line “In compliance with the request of a friend of mine, who wrote me from the East, I called on good-natured, garrulous old Simon Wheeler, and inquired after my friend's friend, Leonidas W.”, what does “garrulous” most nearly mean?
   A. to sit or stand with one leg on each side
   B. to remove a covering from; to reveal
   C. talking too much, especially about unimportant things
   D. friendly and fond of company
8. As used in the story (“And when it come to fair and square jumping on a dead level, he could get over more ground at one straddle than any animal of his breed you ”), what does “straddle” mean?
   A. to sit or stand with one leg on each side
   B. be fond of; be attached to
   C. the act of going on with something
   D. friendly and fond of company
9. As used in the story (“In compliance with the request of a friend of mine, who wrote me from the East, I called on good-natured, garrulous old Simon Wheeler, and i”), what does “garrulous” mean?
   A. full of energy and willing to try new things
   B. talking too much, especially about unimportant things
   C. to sit or stand with one leg on each side
   D. be fond of; be attached to
10. As used in the story (“But as soon as money was up on him, he was a different dog; his underjaw'd begin to stick out like the fo'castle of a steamboat, and his tee”), what does “uncover” mean?
    A. gave someone a task to carry out
    B. talking too much, especially about unimportant things
    C. to remove a covering from; to reveal
    D. full of energy and willing to try new things
11. As used in the story (“At the door I met the sociable Wheeler returning, and he button- holed me and recommenced:”), what does “sociable” mean?
    A. the act of going on with something
    B. to remove a covering from; to reveal
    C. gave someone a task to carry out
    D. friendly and fond of company
12. As used in the story (“I told him a friend of mine had commissioned me to make some inquiries about a cherished companion of his boyhood named Leonidas W.”), what does “cherished” mean?
    A. be fond of; be attached to
    B. to sit or stand with one leg on each side
    C. friendly and fond of company
    D. the act of going on with something

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how tall tales and frontier humor develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how storytelling develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how trickery develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (tall tales and frontier humor, storytelling, trickery) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. D (Leonidas W. Smiley); 2. C (Betting on anything); 3. D (Dan'l Webster); 4. D (He fills Smiley's frog with quail shot); 5. C (In a serious, monotonous, deadpan way); 6. C (to sit or stand with one leg on each side); 7. C (talking too much, especially about unimportant things); 8. A (to sit or stand with one leg on each side); 9. B (talking too much, especially about unimportant things); 10. C (to remove a covering from; to reveal); 11. D (friendly and fond of company); 12. A (be fond of; be attached to)

Essay assignments

Essay: Tall tales and frontier humor

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County teaches about tall tales and frontier humor. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mark Twain develops tall tales and frontier humor in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mark Twain develops tall tales and frontier humor across The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of tall tales and frontier humor. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of tall tales and frontier humor in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mark Twain's choices in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of tall tales and frontier humor, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County's treatment of tall tales and frontier humor in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on tall tales and frontier humor in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on tall tales and frontier humor in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about tall tales and frontier humor in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on tall tales and frontier humor in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Storytelling

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County teaches about storytelling. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mark Twain develops storytelling in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mark Twain develops storytelling across The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of storytelling. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of storytelling in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mark Twain's choices in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County (a recurring

element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of storytelling, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County's treatment of storytelling in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on storytelling in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on storytelling in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about storytelling in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on storytelling in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Trickery

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County teaches about trickery. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Mark Twain develops trickery in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Mark Twain develops trickery across The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Celebrated

Jumping Frog of Calaveras County (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of trickery. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of trickery in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Mark Twain's choices in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of trickery, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County's treatment of trickery in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on trickery in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on trickery in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about trickery in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on trickery in The Celebrated Jumping Frog of Calaveras County, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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